

hard to find, with no one stocking it—and that's only if somebody actually came out with the CD in the first place.

Plan C. Do we have a plan C? Is there really another way? Yes! With a little effort, you could record your old favourites onto your own PC at home. With just a little more than the time it takes to listen to your tunes once, you can record them, and have instant access to them in the future—just like the rest of your collection.

So, what do I need?

Not much actually. At the bare minimum, you need a sound card, which you probably have already. Apart from that, some software and maybe a CD writer.

You start off by hooking up your cassette deck to your PC, and recording the music. Next, it is cleaned up, and made to sound better. Then you organise your music, and burn it onto CDs.

There are several software tools you

one file, or separate files), lay down markers for easy reference whilst editing, adjust the offset levels if the left or right channel is louder, view the recording time, and, quite thoughtfully, the time for which you can record before you run out of disk space. Recording quality is not an issue either. SoundForge is capable of handling higher bit depths and sample rates than your sound card can feed it.

Once you're done recording, it's time to edit. Here, SoundForge blesses you with every tool you need—fades, equalization, volume adjustment, normalisation. Trimming, deleting sections, inserting silence are all accomplished easily, thanks to the superb selection tool, which lets you be as quick, or as precise as required. However, it lacks multi-track editing that can come in handy while making re-mixes, or music CDs with songs mixing into each other.

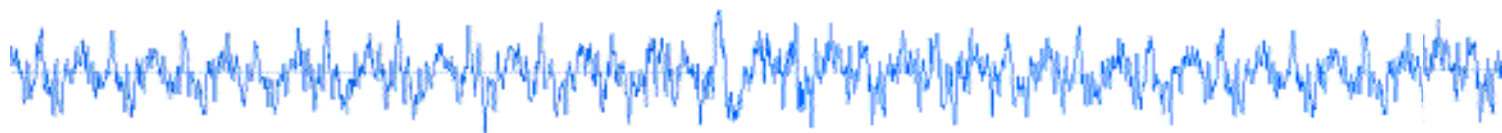
Full-fledged noise reduction requires the Noise Reduction DirectX plug-in from

same Edit view. Switch to the Effects tab on the left, from where you can access most of the required functions. You can apply lots of cool effects such as pitch bending, delays and reverbs.

When it came to noise reduction, Cool Edit Pro performed very well. Most of the noise was removed without much change in the original audio. The cleaned up audio did have a tinny ring to it, but it was quite acceptable. Moving around is not as intuitive as SoundForge, but is never a major handicap to your productivity. The multi-track capabilities are a big boon when you want to mix tracks. Here, you can even use loops, and make your own songs with your own voice track.

Audacity 1.1.3

A simpler audio editing tool you will be hard pressed to find; and a better editing tool you will not find, at this price. It's free! Whilst the interface does not offer much in the way of eye-candy, it's very,



can use to accomplish each task. We'll review tools separated into two main categories—those that record sounds and clean them up by removing noise, equalizing and applying other filters or effects, and those that you can use to sort your collection, rename and play back your files easily.

The process used for your old songs can also be put to other uses, such as recording your voice to send it via e-mail, or to use in presentations. You can even use the same tools to clean up the audio in home movies.

SoundForge 6.0

SoundForge is an old favourite that is widely used to edit wav files on the PC. The program's interface is simple and straightforward—users of earlier versions will feel right at home, and novices won't take long to find their way around.

SoundForge is extremely stable, and responds to most commands quickly. Getting the recording to start takes only a couple of clicks. Pressing the Record button brings up a Recording window, where you can set the recording settings, select how repeated recordings will be saved (in

Sonic Foundry. You can download it at <http://www.sonicfoundry.com/download/step2.asp?DID=167>.

Cool Edit Pro 2.1

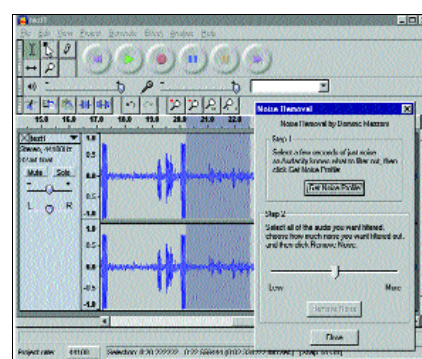
Cool Edit Pro looks way cooler than Sound Forge; Fortunately, that's not at the cost of usability. There are two editing modes—Multi Track and Edit. Multi Track is where you can lay down multiple files, mix them, etc. Edit view is the wave-file editor where you work with one file at a time. You can switch quickly between the modes by pressing [F12].

The Play/Pause, Record and other buttons sit at the bottom left, and are quite convenient to read. Zoom options include zooming into the selected area, and the start, or end of the selection.

Recording in Cool Edit is a breeze. Press the Record button, and a dialog box comes up, asking you to define audio settings—there are options all the way up to 192 KHz 32-bit Stereo. Click on OK to start recording. Whilst recording, the timeline cursor scrolls across the screen, with a real time waveform generated behind it. Once you're done with the recording, move over to editing in the

very easy to use. The main interface has just the basics by way of buttons—selection tools, playback and recording controls, zoom and volume controls. The interface serves as a wave editor, as well as a multi-track mixer. You can accomplish basic editing tasks easily with the selection tool. Some operations, though, take too many steps—something that other editors accomplish in a couple of clicks.

You need to get to grips with the way things happen here—a perfect example is deleting a section from the wave. In any other editor, you just select a section and



The noise removal tool in Audacity details the steps to remove noise

